

Whispers of Wonders



August, 2026

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Editorial

A new school year is like opening a brand-new notebook - full of blank pages, new ideas, and new adventures.

This month, we're celebrating the things that help us make the most of those pages: teamwork, discipline, courage, and perseverance. Whether it's learning something new, helping a friend, or trying again after getting something wrong, every small effort counts.

So, turn the page, stay curious, and most importantly—enjoy the journey!

Happy reading!

Aadrita Chattopadhyay
Editor-in-Chief



CURIOSITY

Corner



Ask • Wonder • Discover

Coordinated Movements in Nature



Teamwork and coordination are not just human skills. All around us, animals move and work together in extraordinary ways. Thousands of starlings can twist and turn through the sky as if they are one giant creature, while schools of fish swim, change direction, and stay together with remarkable precision. In this issue, explore the fascinating murmurations of starlings, written by Aadrita Chattopadhyay, and discover the world of schooling fish, explored by Pavel Steshenko. Together, these stories celebrate the amazing coordination and teamwork found throughout nature.



When the Sky Moves as One

Aadrita Chattopadhyay

Have you ever seen flocks of Starling birds dance so beautifully in the sky that you feel like dancing with them? In each flock, there could be thousands of birds who fly in close coordination. These synchronized movements in Starlings is called Murmuration.

Starlings often display these movements in the evening, just before sunset, during the colder months.

During murmuration, they move in lots of ways - they can go left, right, up, down, sideways and even get apart for a little while and then come back together again. Interestingly, they don't have a leader. Each bird does what the nearby birds are doing and together they create a beautiful pattern.

Murmuration makes the flock look like a giant creature that can scare predators like falcons and hawks.





Fish Swimming Together

By Pavel Steshenko

This summer I went to the Georgia Aquarium in Atlanta. I saw a huge group of fish swimming together. It was really cool to watch!

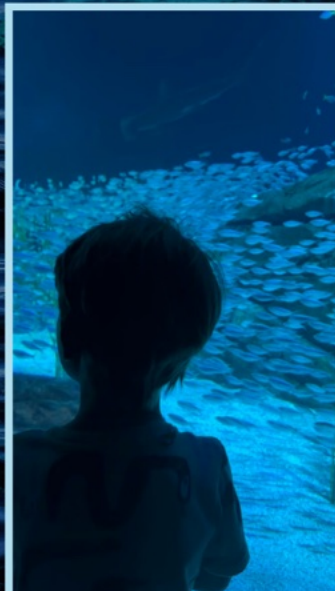
I learned that a group of fish swimming together is called a school. There can be hundreds or even thousands of fish in one school. They can all turn and swim in the same direction at the same time.

I also saw a shark swimming close to the fish. The fish stayed together and quickly swam away. Swimming in a group helps fish stay safe and helps protect the smaller fish.

The most interesting thing is that they don't have a leader. They just watch the other fish and move together. Sometimes a school of fish can even look like one giant fish!

I think it is amazing how fish can work together and help each other.

Fun Fact: Some schools can have millions of fish!



The Power of Perseverance

Research is not always easy. Scientists often face difficult questions, unexpected results, and many attempts that don't work. But they keep going.



Sometimes, finding one answer takes years of asking questions, trying again, and learning from failure. Perseverance is what keeps discovery moving forward.



The stories ahead remind us that when the answers are hard to find, never giving up can be the most important part of the journey.

★ Rolling On: The Story of Perseverance

By Manavdip Saha

NASA launched the Mars rover Perseverance on July 30, 2020, and it landed on Mars on February 18, 2021. The place where it landed once contained a lake, making it an important place to search for signs of ancient life. A 7th grader suggested the name 'Perseverance'. Perseverance means never giving up, even after a number of failures.

When Perseverance tried to collect its first rock sample, it failed because the Martian rock was softer and more crumbly than expected. But the engineers didn't give up. They studied the data from the failed attempt, selected another rock, and tried again. On the next attempt, Perseverance successfully collected a rock sample.

One of the biggest challenges engineers face is that they cannot travel to Mars and repair the rover if something goes wrong. The scientists have to solve problems from Earth by communicating with the rover and using the equipment already on Mars. This is a very difficult task.

Mars keeps creating new challenges for the rover, but the engineers keep finding solutions and helping Perseverance continue its mission.

We should learn from them that we may fail multiple times while doing something, but we should never give up. We should learn from our mistakes, try again, and find a new solution for every problem.





The Mysterious World of Black Holes

By Debashis Chakraborty

A black hole is a region in space where gravity is extremely strong. Its gravity is so powerful that nothing can escape once it crosses a boundary called the event horizon - not even light, which is the fastest thing we know of! Some black holes form when a very massive star reaches the end of its life and collapses under its own gravity.

The nearest known black hole to Earth is called Gaia BH1 which is about 1500 light-years away from us. Another famous black hole is Cygnus X-1, located about 8000 light-years away from Earth. At the center of our own Milky Way galaxy is Sagittarius A, a supermassive black hole with a mass of about four million Suns!

The idea behind black holes came from the laws of gravity described by Albert Einstein's theory of general relativity, published in 1915. The term “black hole” was later popularized by American scientist John Archibald Wheeler in 1967.

We cannot see a black hole directly because no light escapes from it. But scientists can find them by observing their effects on nearby stars and gas. Some black holes can also be studied using X-rays produced by hot material around them.

Black holes are among the most mysterious objects in our universe. We cannot see them directly, and there is still so much we do not know about them. Sometimes, solving a mystery takes patience, curiosity, and perseverance. The mysteries of black holes remind us to keep exploring—even when the answers are not easy to find.

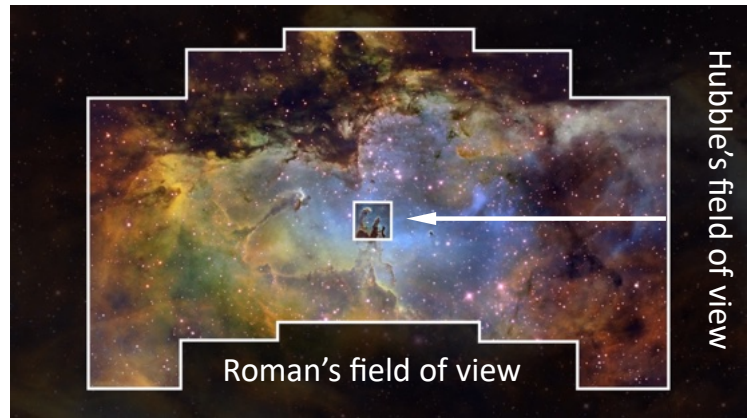




News from Space: The Roman Telescope

On August 30, 2026, NASA launched the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope from Florida. Named after pioneering astronomer Nancy Grace Roman, the new telescope is beginning a mission that could greatly expand our understanding of the universe.

For decades, much of what we have learned about distant galaxies and the universe has come from observations by the Hubble Space Telescope. Roman will take this exploration to a much larger scale. It will survey huge areas of the sky - far more quickly than Hubble, thus creating an enormous collection of cosmic observations.



Roman will help scientists study distant galaxies, dark matter, dark energy, and planets beyond our solar system. By observing so much more of the universe, scientists hope to uncover patterns and discoveries that Hubble's smaller, deeper observations could not reveal on the same scale.

The telescope honors Nancy Grace Roman, whose love for astronomy began at just 11 years old, when she started an astronomy club with her friends. She went on to become NASA's first Chief of Astronomy and played a leading role in developing, advocating for, and securing support for the Hubble Space Telescope. Her pioneering leadership earned her the title "*Mother of Hubble*."

 Hubble opened a window to the universe. Roman is preparing to open that window much wider.



From Birds to Atoms: Coordination Everywhere

By Aadrita Chattopadhyay & Siddhartha Chattopadhyay



A Recent Discovery

When many small parts come together, something amazing can happen

1) Coordination around us



We can see coordination everywhere.
Birds can fly together in beautiful patterns.



In an orchestra, many musicians play together, but we hear one piece of music.

2) What scientists found

Tiny cluster of sodium atoms



Scientists at the University of Vienna studied tiny clusters made of thousands of sodium atoms.

They found that these clusters could show quantum interference—a special wave-like pattern from quantum physics.

3) Why this is special



One tiny object contained thousands of sodium atoms.



The whole object showed quantum interference.



It was not just many separate atoms acting alone.



The whole cluster behaved like one quantum system.



Physicists were seeing quantum behavior belonging to the object as a whole.



4) Big takeaway



The atoms were not coordinating like people or birds.
But the laws of quantum physics allowed the whole cluster to act as one.



*From birds in the sky to atoms in the tiniest world,
many small parts can come together to create something greater than any one part alone.*





CREATIVITY

Corner



unleash the colors within.



Train Your Body, Train Your Mind!

An Interview by Aadrita Chattopadhyay

Karate is about much more than punches and kicks. It teaches children confidence, discipline, self-control, and the importance of keeping going when something feels difficult. This month, our correspondent Aadrita spoke with Mr. Nicholas Maniyar (Mr. Nick), a highly respected and much-loved instructor at Kick's Karate in North Potomac, Gaithersburg. Known for his close connection with his students and his popularity among them, Mr. Nick shared his karate journey, his favorite moves, and the lessons he hopes his students carry with them beyond the dojo.

Q: Can karate help a child become more confident?

Mr. Nick: Absolutely! That's one of the biggest things we work on from the very first class. We teach you to use your voice, make eye contact, and show confidence. Sometimes, if you act confident, that confidence starts to come naturally.

Q: How does karate make you strong in both body and mind?

Mr. Nick: All the kicks, punches, and squats make your body stronger. But karate is also like a puzzle for your brain. You have to remember which foot and hand to use and get every movement right. Sparring is like a mental chess match—you have to think about what you're doing, not just move your body.

Q: Can you explain the different belt levels?

Mr. Nick: We start with a white belt and usually test for a new belt about every three months. In the Little Ninja program, the belts go from white to gold, yellow, orange, green, blue, purple, red, and brown. The goal here is to build a strong foundation. In the Children's Program, there are several levels leading up to black belt. If you train twice a week and work hard, reaching black belt can take about three and a half to four years. But your belt isn't about how good you are. It shows how long you've trained and how far you've come. We set short-term goals, like learning a new kick or earning the next belt, while working toward the long-term goal of becoming a black belt.

Q: What is one of the hardest things to learn in karate?

Mr. Nick: Forms can be very challenging. They are a series of movements that you have to do in the correct order and in the correct way. I've practiced the same form since 2016, and it still isn't perfect! That's what makes forms fun. You can practice them forever, and there is always something you can improve.



Q: How do you stay motivated when you don't feel like practicing?

Mr. Nick: Sometimes I think about all the students and the fun we have in class. That motivates me. But I also use self-discipline. Sometimes you have to say, "I don't want to do this, but I know it's the right thing to do." That discipline helps not only in karate, but in life.

Q: You always say "Never Give Up." How can we get better at perseverance?

Mr. Nick: It's easy to say "never give up," but it's harder to do! When I was a student, my instructor taught me the **100 Times Theory**: practice something 100 times before you give up. If you keep trying, you will probably figure it out! And don't be afraid to ask for help. Your teachers, parents, and instructors are there to help you. Keep trying, and if you really want to give up, start counting to 100. I bet you won't even make it that far!

Q: What should we do when a karate move feels really difficult?

Mr. Nick: Ask your instructor! Different martial arts can teach the same move in different ways, so looking online can sometimes be confusing. Your instructor can show you the technique you're learning and help you understand what you're doing. Sometimes, all it takes is a little practice and the right guidance.

Q: How long have you been a karate instructor?

Mr. Nick: I've been a karate instructor for a little over nine years, since March 2017.

Q: What are the most important lessons karate has taught you?

Mr. Nick: I would say self-control, discipline, and perseverance. Self-control helps you stand still and listen so you can learn. Discipline means doing the right thing even when nobody asks you to. And perseverance means saying, "Even if this is hard, I'm going to keep trying."

Q: What is your favorite karate move?

Mr. Nick: Everyone here knows my favorite is the sidekick! It looks simple, but doing it correctly takes a lot of strength and practice.

Q: What is your favorite memory as a karate instructor?

Mr. Nick: My favorite part is watching students grow. I remember Mr. Ryan when he was a first-degree black belt, and I've watched him work all the way up to his third-degree black belt. Seeing someone start at the beginning, work through the belts, reach their goals, and keep going is what I love most about being an instructor.

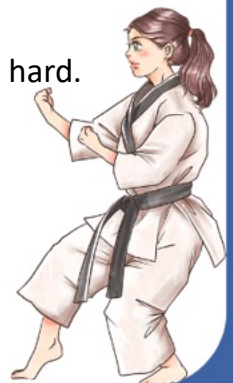




Q: What advice would you give to kids who want to start karate?

Mr. Nick: The first thing is: try. It doesn't hurt to try, so try something. And that's not just karate. If you want to play a sport, try the sport. If you want to start getting better at chess, start playing chess. So, just try karate.

Then the next thing is to *do your best*. Put your maximum effort in, even when it's hard. And I think that applies not just to karate, but to anything.





Come See Karate in Action!

An *Invitation* from Mr Nick

One of the best ways to learn about karate is to see it up close and watch it in action. Luckily, we have a special opportunity coming up this Labor Day morning!

If you live nearby, don't miss this one. This Labor day, Kicks Karate will have a special class, and our magazine readers are invited to come by and see what happens.

 September 7, 2026

 9:30 AM

 Kicks Karate, North Potomac, Gaithersburg, MD

And there will be plenty to see!

If you're a new kid, you'll get a chance to break a board. You'll also get to see something you might not expect—the instructors themselves will be demonstrating their martial arts and karate skills, not just teaching the students.

And don't just watch. Ask questions! Wondering how a move works? Curious about what it feels like to train? Have a question you forgot to ask during the interview? Go ahead and ask. Mr. Nick and the instructors will be happy to answer.

Can't make it because you live somewhere else? You can still be part of the conversation. Send us your karate questions, and Mr. Nick will be happy to answer them for our readers.

So, if you're close enough to stop by this Labor Day morning, come see karate for yourself!





Book Review



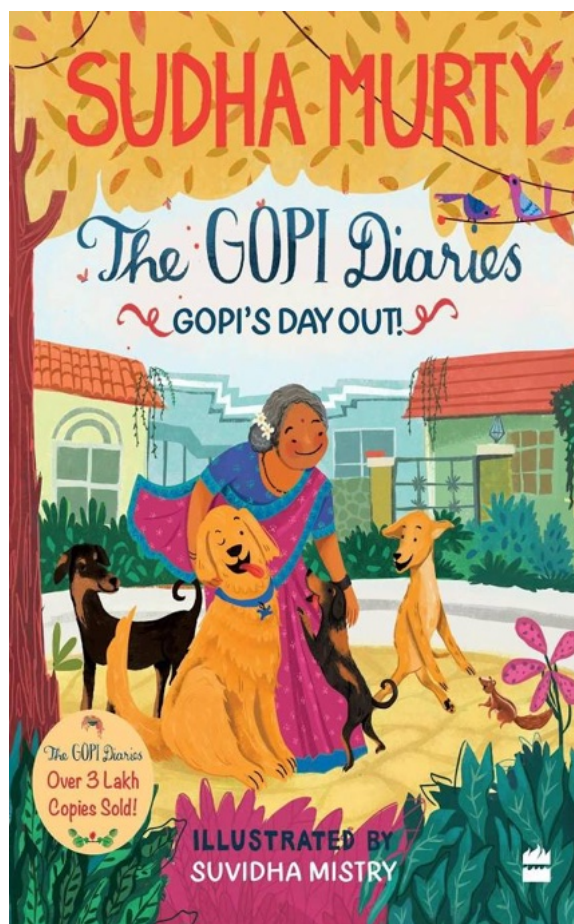
By Sharanya Das

The Gopi Diaries - Gopi's Day Out By Sudha Murty

Gopi's Day Out is a really interesting story. It is about Sudha Murty's dog, Gopi, who starts chasing birds and squirrels and suddenly gets lost and cannot find his way home. While Amma (mother), Appa (father), Ajji (grand mother), and Tachi Ajji (grand mother's sister) are looking for him, Gopi meets many other dogs and explores different places.

In this story, Gopi learns about the lives of other dogs and how they help people in many ways. He sees how street dogs have to find food, shelter, and safety for themselves. Oh, I almost forgot to mention that Gopi makes a new friend too! Gopi also accidentally goes to a dog competition and wins first place.

I like this book a lot because it taught me more about dogs and helped me understand that not every dog has a safe and happy home like Gopi. It made me feel that we should be kind and caring toward animals, especially those living on the streets. I think you will enjoy going on Gopi's adventure too!



The Little Boy's Toy

By Sharanya Das

There was a little boy
who had a little toy
the toy was quite old
and it had a tiny mold
the mold was of a cat
which was really really fat
the face looked like a cow
and it loved to say meow
I called the toy odd
the boy called me odd!





Rakhi Bandhan

By Katha Chowdhury

Rakhi Bandhan, also known as Raksha Bandhan, is a significant cultural tradition of India. The phrase 'Raksha Bandhan' literally translates to 'bond of protection', which is exactly what this sweet little tradition is about. The ritual goes that sisters tie a sacred string on their brother's hand, and the brother promises to protect her.

Though not invented by him, Nobel laureate Kabiguru Rabindranath Tagore popularized Raksha Bandhan in modern India, and it is still quite a ubiquitous custom all around the country. A metaphorical look into Raksha Bandhan would be that the sister is implying 'tying' her bond with her brother and strengthening it by tightening the knot.

Swami Vivekananda mentioned Raksha Bandhan while retelling the historical tales of Rajput valor, and emphasized the fact that a simple piece of thread or yarn can be linked to a sense of protection, responsibility, unconditional care, empathy and bonding.

Even though Raksha Bandhan is rooted in Hindu tradition, many other religions participate secularly, which expresses the togetherness this activity brings. One may call the essence of this little custom as sweet as the smell of petrichor, considering the feeling of friendliness it brings to the hearts of people.

To conclude, Raksha Bandhan is one of India's wonderful rituals which has a deep, underlying history, and a philosophical meaning beyond just 'tying a string'.



A Burst of Colors

By Sharanya Das

Saranya has drawn and filled this beautiful mandala with bright, vibrant colors and wonderful patterns. Each little shape adds something special, creating a picture that feels joyful and full of life.



A Glimpse of the Sky

By Aadrita Chattopadhyay

Aadrita looked up and captured this beautiful view of blue skies, fluffy clouds, and delicate pink blossoms.



A cluster of five watercolor-style balloons in various colors: yellow, orange, blue, red, and purple. The balloons have soft, blended edges and are set against a light cream background with a subtle wavy texture. The word "FUN" is written in large, white, outlined capital letters across the center of the balloons.

FUN

Corner



Word Scrambles

The letters have gotten all mixed up! Unscramble each word to reveal a special quality that can help us work together, face challenges, and never give up.

V-A-R-E-R-B-Y

--	--	--	--	--	--	--

G-E-R-A-O-C-U

--	--	--	--	--	--	--

G-H-I-P-L-E-N

--	--	--	--	--	--	--

S-R-I-T-E-P-S

--	--	--	--	--	--	--

N-I-T-A-P-E-T

--	--	--	--	--	--	--

C-C-U-S-S-S-E

--	--	--	--	--	--	--

Answers to last issue's word scrambles:

1. TAIL, 2. SHIP, 3. OCEAN, 4. PIRATE, 5. BUBBLES



Find the Words

Hidden among the letters are words connected to teamwork, courage, confidence, and perseverance. Search carefully—can you find all 15?

M	T	T	P	A	T	I	E	N	C	E	G	D	A	F
D	E	S	U	R	G	B	B	F	T	Y	U	C	T	G
S	A	F	W	H	W	R	H	T	L	A	C	O	S	F
A	M	J	I	T	Q	A	A	H	K	X	B	N	M	V
B	W	S	T	E	F	V	G	H	F	D	W	F	B	N
C	O	U	R	A	G	E	K	S	R	S	P	I	R	S
D	R	C	E	U	C	R	A	U	I	U	S	D	P	T
E	K	C	S	T	J	Y	S	P	E	N	H	E	L	P
F	G	E	P	C	A	M	N	P	N	Z	M	N	C	D
F	H	S	E	L	S	D	V	O	D	X	T	C	T	A
O	T	S	C	W	C	P	E	R	S	E	V	E	R	E
R	E	U	T	A	C	S	U	T	H	Y	Z	E	Y	S
T	S	D	I	S	C	I	P	L	I	N	E	L	K	M
K	I	N	D	N	E	S	S	T	P	S	Q	V	N	I
G	Q	A	R	F	D	A	L	K	G	X	Z	N	V	D

TEAMWORK	CONFIDENCE	SUPPORT	FRIENDSHIP	PATIENCE
COURAGE	PERSEVERE	RESPECT	TOGETHER	DISCIPLINE
BRAVERY	HELP	KINDNESS	EFFORT	SUCCESS

Spot the Difference

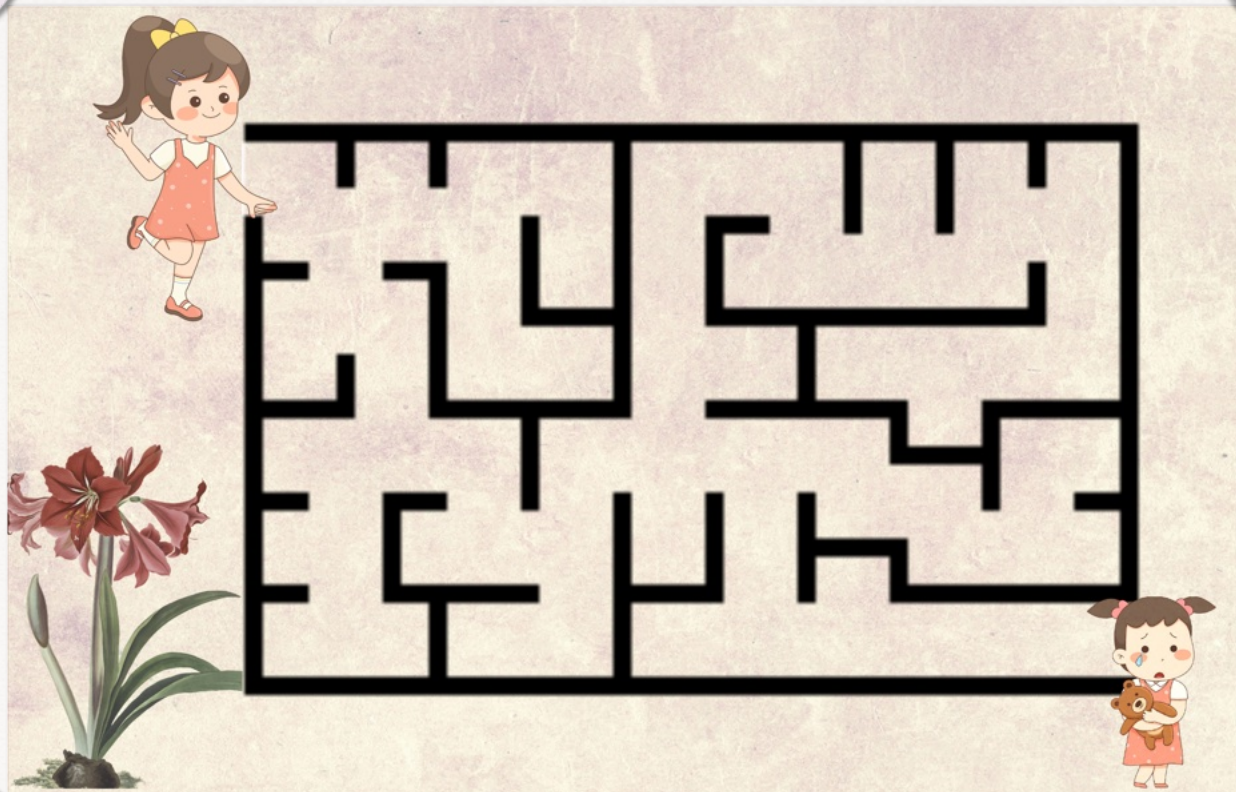
Look closely! These two pictures may seem exactly the same, but 5 sneaky differences are hiding in plain sight.

Can you spot them all?



Maze

 Oh no! Little sister needs help, and her big sister is on her way. Can you guide her through the maze so she can reach her sister and bring some comfort?





Crack the Secret Word!

Five letters are hiding in the clues below. Read each pair of words carefully. Find the letter that is in the first word but not in the second word. Write down each answer. Then put all five letters together to discover the secret word!



Clue 1

I am in BAT, but not in CAT. What letter am I?

Answer: _____



Clue 2

I am in RAN, but not in CAN. What letter am I?

Answer: _____



Clue 3

I am in CAT, but not in COT. What letter am I?

Answer: _____



Clue 4

I am in VET, but not in BET. What letter am I?

Answer: _____



Clue 5

I am in PET, but not in PAT. What letter am I?

Answer: _____



Put Your Letters Together. Can you find the secret word?

Answer: _____



The Mystery of the Missing School Item!

It was Monday morning. Rory was ready for school. She had her backpack, her pencil case, her book, her lunch, and her water bottle.

But when she arrived at school, she suddenly said:
“Oh no! Something important is missing!”

What could she have forgotten? Can you help solve the mystery?

Read the clues carefully and cross out the things that cannot be the missing item.



Clue 1

Rory drank from her *water bottle* on the way to school.



Clue 2

At school, Rory opened her backpack and took out her *book*.



Clue 3

When the teacher asked her to write, Rory took out a pencil from the *pencil case*.



Clue 4

Rory was carrying all of these things in her *backpack*.

What did Rory forget at home? Can you figure it out?



Detective's Tip:

Before leaving for school, take one minute to check your backpack. A little preparation can save a big problem later!

A warm, golden sunset scene with tall grass silhouettes in the foreground and a bright sun in the background. The text "Thank you" is overlaid in white, stylized font.

Thank you